

Setting up NGINX for PHP

From Development Server to Production-Ready
Web Server

What We're Building

Current Setup (Development)

```
php -S localhost:8000
```

- Single-threaded
- Development only
- No static file optimization
- Limited concurrent users

New Setup (Production-Ready)

NGINX + PHP-FPM (PHP FastCGI Process Manager)

- Multi-threaded
- Production ready
- Optimized static file serving
- Handles thousands of users

Understanding the Architecture

| PHP Built-in Server

Browser → PHP -S → PHP Script

Single process handles everything

NGINX + PHP-FPM

Browser → NGINX → PHP-FPM → PHP Script
↓
Static Files (direct)

**NGINX handles static files, PHP-FPM processes
PHP**

Step 1: Install PHP-FPM

Windows

PHP-FPM is included with PHP 7.4+ on Windows

```
# Check if available  
php --version  
php-cgi --version
```

not compatible error

In the case you have an error using `php-cgi.exe`.

```
c:\php>.\php-cgi.exe -b 127.0.0.1:9000 -c
```

```
C:\php\php.ini
```

PHP Warning:

```
'C:\WINDOWS\SYSTEM32\VCRUNTIME140.dll'
```

14.34 is not compatible with this PHP build linked
with 14.44 in Unknown on line 0

Download and install the latest Microsoft Visual C++ Redistributable for Visual Studio 2019 or later (such as 2022):

1. Go to Microsoft's official Visual Studio download page:

<https://visualstudio.microsoft.com/downloads/>

2. Scroll down to the "Other Tools, Frameworks, and Redistributables" section.
3. Select the appropriate version for your system (x64 for 64-bit Windows or x86 for 32-bit Windows).

macOS

```
# PHP-FPM comes with Homebrew PHP  
brew install php
```

```
# Or if you need to reinstall  
brew reinstall php
```

```
> brew list php | grep php-fpm  
/opt/homebrew/Cellar/php/8.4.11/sbin/php-fpm  
/opt/homebrew/Cellar/php/8.4.11/.bottle/etc/php/8.4/php-fpm.d/www.conf  
/opt/homebrew/Cellar/php/8.4.11/.bottle/etc/php/8.4/php-fpm.conf  
/opt/homebrew/Cellar/php/8.4.11/.bottle/var/log/php-fpm.log  
/opt/homebrew/Cellar/php/8.4.11/share/man/man8/php-fpm.8
```

| Linux (Ubuntu/Debian)

```
sudo apt update  
sudo apt install php-fpm php-mysql
```

Step 2: Configure PHP-FPM

Start PHP-FPM Service

macOS:

```
brew services start php  
# or manually: php-fpm
```

`brew services` command shows the `brew services` that are running on your system.

```
smcho@m4 www> brew services  
Name  Status  User  File  
mysql started smcho ~/Library/LaunchAgents/homebrew.mxcl.mysql.plist  
nginx started smcho ~/Library/LaunchAgents/homebrew.mxcl.nginx.plist  
php   started smcho ~/Library/LaunchAgents/homebrew.mxcl.php.plist
```

Linux:

```
sudo systemctl start php-fpm      # CentOS/RHEL  
sudo systemctl start php8.1-fpm   # Ubuntu (adjust version)  
sudo systemctl enable php8.1-fpm  # Auto-start on boot
```

Windows:

Assuming that PHP is installed in c:\PHP.

1. Run php-cgi.exe.

```
cd C:\php  
.\php-cgi.exe -b 127.0.0.1:9000 -c C:\php\php.ini
```

2. PHP-FPM runs automatically with proper NGINX configuration

Health Check

```
PS C:\nginx> netstat -ano | findstr :9000
TCP    127.0.0.1:9000      0.0.0.0:0          LISTENING        93724
TCP    127.0.0.1:9000      127.0.0.1:50074    TIME_WAIT        0

PS C:\nginx> Get-CimInstance Win32_Process -Filter "ProcessId=93724" | Select-Object ProcessId, Name, CommandLine

ProcessId Name          CommandLine
-----
93724 php-cgi.exe
```

Step 3: Basic NGINX Configuration for PHP

Find Your NGINX Configuration File

- **Windows:**

`C:\tools\nginx\conf\nginx.conf` (choco)

or `C:\nginx\conf\nginx.conf` (manual)

- **macOS:** `/usr/local/etc/nginx/nginx.conf`

(/opt/homebrew/, instead of /usr/local/, for Apple Silicon Mac)

- **Linux:** `/etc/nginx/nginx.conf`

Create a Basic Configuration

Replace the `server` block in `nginx.conf`:

You can copy and paste the code block from module1/code/5_Webserver_using_NGINX).

```
server {
    listen 80;
    server_name localhost;
    root /var/www/html; # Adjust path for your system
    index index.php index.html index.htm;

    location / {
        try_files $uri $uri/ =404;
    }

    location ~ \.php$ {
        fastcgi_pass 127.0.0.1:9000; # PHP-FPM address
        fastcgi_index index.php;
        fastcgi_param SCRIPT_FILENAME $document_root$fastcgi_script_name;
        include fastcgi_params;
    }
}
```


Server Block Overview

Make sure you have the correct **root** for your system!

```
server {  
    listen 8080;  
    server_name localhost;  
    root /usr/local/var/www;  
    index index.php index.html;  
}
```

- **listen 8080:** HTTP port (use 8080 on macOS instead of 80)
- **server_name localhost:** Domain (change to your own domain if needed)

Static File Handling

```
location / {  
    try_files $uri $uri/ =404;  
}
```

- Tries to serve the exact file or folder
- If not found, returns 404
- Ensures clean URL support (e.g., /about)

PHP File Handling

```
location ~ /\.php$ {  
    fastcgi_pass 127.0.0.1:9000;  
    fastcgi_index index.php;  
    fastcgi_param SCRIPT_FILENAME $document_root$fastcgi_script_name;  
    include fastcgi_params;  
}
```

- Matches .php files via regex
- Forwards request to PHP-FPM at 127.0.0.1:9000
- Passes script path and required FastCGI parameters

How It Works

1. Browser requests

<http://localhost:8080/index.php>

2. NGINX matches .php and forwards to PHP-FPM

3. PHP-FPM executes index.php and returns output

4. NGINX sends a response back to the browser

Efficient, production-ready setup for PHP apps

Step 4: Restart nginx

- **Mac:** `nginx -s reload`
- **Linux (Ubuntu):** `sudo systemctl restart nginx`

For windows:

- `nginx -s reload` for the simplest (two terminals) case.
- For other cases, stop and start again.

Step 5: Create a Test PHP File

Create **info.php** in your web root

```
<?php  
phpinfo();  
?>
```

Create `php_fpm_test.php` for API testing

```
<?php
header('Content-Type: application/json');

$response = [
    'message' => 'NGINX + PHP-FPM is working!',
    'server' => $_SERVER['SERVER_SOFTWARE'] ?? 'Unknown',
    'php_version' => PHP_VERSION,
    'timestamp' => date('Y-m-d H:i:s'),
    'method' => $_SERVER['REQUEST_METHOD'],
    'uri' => $_SERVER['REQUEST_URI']
];

echo json_encode($response, JSON_PRETTY_PRINT);
?>
```

- PHP automatically generates this as a response.

```
HTTP/1.1 200 OK
Server: nginx/1.24.0
Content-Type: application/json
Content-Length: 226
Connection: keep-alive

{
  "message": "NGINX + PHP-FPM is working!",
  "server": "nginx/1.24.0",
  "php_version": "8.2.12",
  "timestamp": "2025-08-02 18:01:30",
  "method": "GET",
  "uri": "/php_fpm_test.php"
}
```


Step 6: Start Services and Test

| 1. Start PHP-FPM (if not already running)

macOS:

```
brew services start php
```

Linux:

```
sudo systemctl start php8.1-fpm # Ubuntu  
sudo systemctl start php-fpm    # CentOS
```

Windows

2. Reload NGINX Configuration

macOS & Linux:

```
nginx -s reload
```

Windows was explained in earlier pages.

3. Test Your Setup

- Visit: <http://localhost/info.php> (or :8080 on macOS)
- Visit: http://localhost/php_fpm_test.php

You should see the PHP info and the JSON